CSE 470 · THIKTHAK TEAM

ThikThak Setup Guide

How to install everything ThikThak needs on your Windows PC, step by step from scratch.

Updated 6 November 2026 · Windows 10 or 11 (64-bit) · Every tool in this guide is free

What you'll install

#	Tool	What it does	Get it from
1	VS Code	Code editor	code.visualstudio.com
2	Git	Saves versions of the code and shares them	git-scm.com
3	GitHub account	Gives you access to our shared repo	github.com
4	XAMPP 8.5.12	PHP 8.5, the MariaDB database and phpMyAdmin in one installer	apachefriends.org
5	Composer	Installs Laravel and the other PHP packages	getcomposer.org
6	Node.js (LTS)	Builds the CSS and JavaScript	nodejs.org

Before you start

- You need an account that can install apps, and an internet connection.
- **Already have Laravel Herd, MySQL Server, WAMP or an older XAMPP?** Uninstall them first in **Settings → Apps → Installed apps**. They fight with XAMPP over ports 80 and 3306 and bring a second copy of PHP.
- Run every command in this guide in **Command Prompt**: press Start, type `cmd`, press Enter.
- After installing each tool, close Command Prompt and open a new one, so Windows notices the new tool.

Part A Install the tools

1 Install VS Code

1. Go to **code.visualstudio.com** and click **Download for Windows**.
2. Run the installer. On **Select Additional Tasks**, keep **Add to PATH** ticked. Ticking **Add "Open with Code" action** is handy too.
3. Open VS Code, go to Extensions (`Ctrl+Shift+X`) and install these three:
   - **Laravel** (publisher: Laravel)
   - **PHP Intelephense** (Ben Mewburn). The free features are enough, so don't buy a licence.
   - **Tailwind CSS IntelliSense** (Tailwind Labs)
4. Make Command Prompt the built-in terminal: press `Ctrl+Shift+P`, type **Terminal: Select Default Profile**, and choose **Command Prompt**.

2 Install Git

1. Go to **git-scm.com**, click **Download for Windows**, and download the 64-bit installer.
2. Run it. On **Choosing the default editor used by Git**, pick **Use Visual Studio Code as Git's default editor**. Leave every other screen on its default.
3. Open a new Command Prompt and check it works:

   ```
   git --version
   ```

4. Tell Git who you are. Use the same email as your GitHub account:

   ```
   git config --global user.name "Your Full Name"
   git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
   ```

3 Create a GitHub account

1. Sign up at **github.com**. The free plan is all we need.
2. Send your GitHub username to Saad.
3. Accept the invite when it arrives, from your email or **github.com/notifications**. Invites expire after 7 days.

4 Install XAMPP 8.5.12

1. Go to **apachefriends.org**, open **Download**, and get **XAMPP for Windows 8.5.12**. Don't pick 8.4 or 8.3: the whole team needs the same PHP version.
2. Run the installer. Windows may stop you along the way:
   - **A message says the app was blocked, with only OK and Get apps from Microsoft Store, and the installer closes.** This is Smart App Control, and it blocks XAMPP because the installer isn't digitally signed. Open **Windows Security → App & browser control → Smart App Control settings**, choose **Off**, and run the installer again. Smart App Control would also block XAMPP's own programs, so it has to stay off. Your antivirus keeps running.
   - **A blue "Windows protected your PC" box.** Click **More info → Run anyway**.
   - **A warning about UAC (User Account Control).** Click **OK**. It only asks you not to install into Program Files.
3. On the components screen, **Apache, MySQL, PHP and phpMyAdmin** must stay ticked. You can untick the rest (FileZilla, Mercury, Tomcat, Perl, Webalizer, Fake Sendmail).
4. Keep the install folder as `C:\xampp`.
5. Finish with **start the Control Panel** ticked. If Windows Firewall asks about Apache or mysqld, click **Allow**.
6. In the XAMPP Control Panel, click **Start** next to **Apache** and next to **MySQL**. Both names turn green.
7. Open **http://localhost/phpmyadmin** in your browser. If phpMyAdmin loads, XAMPP works.

The panel says "MySQL", but XAMPP actually runs MariaDB, which works like MySQL. That's expected, and Laravel is set up for it.

5 Switch on PHP extensions

Laravel needs a few PHP extensions that XAMPP may ship switched off.

1. In the XAMPP Control Panel, on the **Apache** row, click **Config → PHP (php.ini)**. The file opens in Notepad.
2. Press `Ctrl+F` and find each line below. If it starts with `;`, delete the `;`. If a line isn't there at all, type it in next to the other `extension=` lines.

```
extension=curl
extension=fileinfo
extension=gd
extension=intl
extension=mbstring
extension=openssl
extension=pdo_mysql
extension=zip
```

3. Save with `Ctrl+S`. Then click **Stop** and **Start** on Apache in the Control Panel.

6 Install Composer

1. Go to **getcomposer.org/download** and download **Composer-Setup.exe**.
2. Run it. Leave **Developer mode** unticked.
3. When it asks for the PHP executable, choose `C:\xampp\php\php.exe`. If it offers to add PHP to your PATH, accept.
4. Skip the proxy screen and click **Install**.
5. Open a new Command Prompt and check both:

```
php -v
composer -V
```

`php -v` must say **PHP 8.5.12**. If it shows another version, see Troubleshooting at the end.

7 Install Node.js

1. Go to **nodejs.org** and download the **LTS** Windows installer (`.msi`). Version 24 or newer works.
2. Run it with the default options. On **Tools for Native Modules**, leave the box unticked; we don't need it.
3. Open a new Command Prompt and check:

```
node -v
npm -v
```

Checkpoint: is everything installed?

Open a new Command Prompt and run each command. You should see:

Command	You should see
`git --version`	git version 2.x
`php -v`	PHP 8.5.12
`composer -V`	Composer version 2.x
`node -v`	v24 or newer
`npm -v`	a version number

Part B Get ThikThak running

8 Download the project

1. Make a folder **outside OneDrive**, because OneDrive struggles with the thousands of small files a Laravel project has. For example:

   ```
   mkdir C:\Projects
   cd /d C:\Projects
   ```

2. On our GitHub repo page, click the green **Code** button and copy the HTTPS link. Then run the command below, with the link you copied in place of the example:

   ```
   git clone https://github.com/OWNER/thikthak.git
   cd thikthak
   ```

3. The first time, a window asks you to sign in to GitHub. Choose **Sign in with your browser** and approve.

9 Install the project's packages

```
composer install
npm install
copy .env.example .env
php artisan key:generate
```

`composer install` and `npm install` take a few minutes the first time. The `.env` file holds your own local settings and never goes to GitHub.

10 Create the database

1. In the XAMPP Control Panel, make sure MySQL is running (green).
2. Open **http://localhost/phpmyadmin** and click **New** in the left sidebar.
3. Database name: `thikthak`. Collation: `utf8mb4_unicode_ci`. Click **Create**.
4. Open `.env` in VS Code and check these lines. They should already be right, because XAMPP's `root` user has no password:

   ```
   DB_CONNECTION=mariadb
   DB_HOST=127.0.0.1
   DB_PORT=3306
   DB_DATABASE=thikthak
   DB_USERNAME=root
   DB_PASSWORD=
   ```

11 Create the tables and test data

```
php artisan migrate --seed
php artisan storage:link
```

The first command builds every table and adds test data. The second lets uploaded photos show up in the browser.

12 Run the app

Open two Command Prompt windows (or two VS Code terminals) in the `thikthak` folder.

WINDOW 1

```
php artisan serve
```

WINDOW 2

```
npm run dev
```

Now open **http://127.0.0.1:8000** in your browser. Keep both windows open while you work, and press `Ctrl+C` in each one to stop.

> If the ThikThak home page loads, you're fully set up.

Part C Every time you work

1. **Start the database.** In XAMPP, click Start on MySQL, and on Apache too if you want phpMyAdmin.
2. **Get your teammates' latest work.** The last three commands pick up new packages and tables. They're safe to run every time.

   ```
   git switch main
   git pull
   composer install
   npm install
   php artisan migrate
   ```

3. **Work on your own branch.**

   FIRST TIME FOR A FEATURE

   ```
   git switch -c feature/f4-service-requests
   ```

   COMING BACK TO IT LATER

   ```
   git switch feature/f4-service-requests
   git merge main
   ```

4. **Run the app** as in Step 12, and write your code.
5. **Save and share your work.**

   ```
   git add .
   git commit -m "Describe what you changed"
   git push -u origin feature/f4-service-requests
   ```

   Then on GitHub, open a **Pull Request** into `main` and ask a teammate to review it.
6. **Before you shut down the PC,** click Stop on MySQL in XAMPP. Shutting down while it runs can damage the database.

Team rules

- Never commit `.env`. It holds your own settings, and Git already ignores it.
- Never push straight to `main`. Every change goes in through a Pull Request.
- Commit your own work from your own GitHub account. The faculty checks each person's commits.
- To change a table that's already on `main`, write a new migration. Don't edit the old one.
- Don't run `composer update` on your own. It changes package versions for everyone, so ask in the group first.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Apache won't start: port 80 in use	Another program uses port 80. Click **Netstat** in the XAMPP Control Panel to see which one, then close or uninstall it (often Herd, IIS or another XAMPP).
XAMPP installer closes after a "blocked" message with only OK and "Get apps from Microsoft Store"	Smart App Control is on. Turn it off in Windows Security → App & browser control → Smart App Control settings, then run the installer again (Step 4).
MySQL won't start: port 3306 in use	MySQL Server is still installed, or its service is still running after the uninstall. Uninstall it in Settings → Apps, then restart the PC.
`'php' is not recognized`	PHP isn't on your PATH. Run Composer-Setup again, accept adding PHP to the PATH, then open a new Command Prompt.
`php -v` doesn't show 8.5.12	Run `where php`. If the first line isn't `C:\xampp\php\php.exe`, uninstall the other PHP (Herd or an older XAMPP).
Composer says an extension is missing (`ext-zip`, `ext-intl`, `ext-gd`, `ext-fileinfo`)	Switch it on in `php.ini` (Step 5), then run the command again.
Composer complains about the PHP version or the lock file	You aren't on PHP 8.5.12. Check `php -v`.
`SQLSTATE[HY000] [2002]` … connection refused	MySQL isn't running. Start it in the XAMPP Control Panel.
`SQLSTATE[HY000] [1049] Unknown database 'thikthak'`	Create the database (Step 10).
"No application encryption key has been specified"	Run `php artisan key:generate`.
"Vite manifest not found", or the page has no styling	`npm run dev` isn't running. Start it in a second window (Step 12).
`'npm' is not recognized`	Reinstall Node.js, then open a new Command Prompt.

Stuck? Post the exact error message in the group chat, along with the step you were on.